



Mahshad Koohgoli, CEO, Protecode

“Open Source licence management is like any other quality management process.”

Someone rightly observed: “All code is guilty, until proven innocent.” Ask the members of any software development team, and they will agree that tracking open source software components that have gone into building a software product, understanding the associated licences and related legal obligations, and shipping a ‘clean’ product to market—all within the stipulated time—is a task easier said than done.

Vandana Sharma of LFY Bureau caught up with **Mahshad Koohgoli, CEO, Protecode**, to gauge the complexity in the open source licence landscape, and learn the best practices that both software development teams and independent developers must adopt, if they want to have clean code at the end of the product development cycle.

Q To begin, could you tell us how many types of open source licences there are, and what their related obligations are?

Broadly speaking, we divide open source licences into two categories—permissive licences and restrictive licences. Permissive licences put very little restrictions on how you modify and use the modified version of the code. Good examples are BSD (Berkeley Software Distribution), or New BSD, Apache version 2, and Mozilla Public Licence (MPL). These licences don’t put onerous restrictions on users, except that the licence generally has to be cited, and a copy of the text of the licence needs to be distributed along with the code. BSD, or the modified version of BSD, is also very simple—and any company that’s not looking for copyleft licences can usually opt for this one.

The other type of licence is the restrictive open source licence. We call these copyleft licences, as opposed to copyright licences. These are also sometimes called viral licences. A good example is the GNU GPL (General Public License). Restrictive licences try to keep the code open source—along with any modification of the code, or any product based on it. So if you use code with such licences as the GPL, you are bound by the terms of the licence to also release your own code under the GPL licence as open source code.